

Cold Email Playbook

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A step-by-step guide to setting up cold email infrastructure that lands in the inbox and gets replies.

Before You Send a Single Email

Most cold email fails before the first send. Not because the copy was bad. Because the infrastructure was wrong.

You can write the best email in your industry and still land in spam if your domain isn't authenticated, your inboxes aren't warmed, or your list is full of dead addresses. Infrastructure first. Copy second. That order is not negotiable.

This playbook walks the whole build in the order you should actually do it:

1. Infrastructure setup
2. Authentication (SPF, DKIM, DMARC)
3. Warmup
4. List building
5. Sequence structure
6. Deliverability maintenance
7. Reply handling
8. Troubleshooting

Budget 3 to 5 weeks from "buying domains" to "sending at full volume." Anyone telling you it's a weekend job is selling you a burned domain.

Tools referenced throughout: Instantly (sending + warmup), Google Workspace (inbox hosting), Mailgun (transactional and infrastructure sends), GoHighLevel (CRM, pipeline, booking follow-up). Substitutes exist for all of them. The principles don't change.

Phase 1 — Infrastructure Setup

Never send cold email from your main domain

Your primary domain — the one your website, your client comms, your invoices, and your booking confirmations run on — should never touch a cold campaign. Ever.

Here's why. Cold email always generates some spam complaints. Even good cold email. Someone has a bad morning, hits "Report spam," and that signal attaches to your *sending domain's reputation*. Enough of those and mailbox providers start filtering everything from that domain — including the reply you send to a warm lead, the proposal you send to a paying client, and the password reset from your own tools.

Domain reputation damage is slow to build and slow to repair. Months, sometimes. There is no support ticket you can file to undo it.

The rule: buy separate sending domains, keep the main domain clean, and treat sending domains as consumable assets. If one gets burned, you retire it and spin up another. That is the whole point.

Buying secondary domains

Buy close variants of your brand so recipients still recognize you. Say your main domain is *coreflareagency.com*. Good secondaries look like:

- getcoreflare.com
- coreflare.co
- trycoreflare.com
- coreflarehq.com
- joincoreflare.com

Rules for picking them:

- **Stay recognizable.** A prospect who Googles the domain should land somewhere that looks like you.
- **Prefer .com, then .co / .io.** Avoid cheap TLDs — .xyz, .top, .click, .info. Some carry poor reputation by association and get filtered harder before you've sent anything.
- **Check the history.** Before buying an aftermarket domain, look it up on archive.org and run it through a blacklist checker. A domain that used to be a spam operation comes pre-poisoned.
- **Redirect them.** Point each secondary domain at your main site with a 301 redirect. An unresolving domain looks disposable — to prospects and to filters.

Inboxes and realistic send limits

Host inboxes on Google Workspace or Microsoft 365. Both have real reputation weight behind them. Set up **2 to 3 inboxes per domain** — more than that concentrates risk and starts looking like a farm.

Use real, human names. samuel@getcoreflare.com, sam.e@getcoreflare.com. Not info@, sales@, hello@, outreach@. Role addresses get filtered harder and read as bulk.

Fill out each inbox properly: real display name, a profile photo, a plain signature. An inbox with no identity behind it is a signal.

Per-inbox daily send limits — treat these as ceilings, not targets:

Stage	Cold emails per inbox per day	Notes
Weeks 1–2 (warmup only)	0 cold	Warmup traffic only. No campaign sends.
Week 3	5–10	First live sends. Watch bounces daily.
Week 4	15–20	Only if bounce rate is clean.
Week 5	25–30	Approaching steady state.
Week 6+ (steady state)	30–50	Keep warmup running underneath, permanently.

Thirty to fifty per inbox per day is the safe operating band. Google Workspace technically allows far more. Ignore that number — it's a platform limit, not a deliverability limit. Cold traffic behaves differently than normal mail and gets scrutinized accordingly.

How many inboxes do you need?

Work backwards from your volume target. Assume **40 cold sends per inbox per day** at steady state.

Target sends/day	Inboxes needed	Domains needed (at 3 inboxes each)
200	5	2
400	10	4
800	20	7
1,500	38	13

Formula: **inboxes** = **daily target** ÷ **40**, then **domains** = **inboxes** ÷ **3**, rounded up.

Before you scale that math, ask whether you actually need the volume. Most people chasing 1,500 sends a day have a targeting problem, not a volume problem. Tightening the list usually beats tripling the infrastructure. Quality over quantity. Always.

Connect every inbox to Instantly (or your sender of choice) and enable rotation, so sends distribute evenly across the pool instead of hammering one mailbox.

Phase 2 — Authentication (SPF, DKIM, DMARC)

This is where most guides wave their hands. Don't skip it. Unauthenticated mail gets filtered on arrival — the copy never gets a vote.

Three DNS records. Each answers a different question a receiving mail server asks.

Record	The question it answers
SPF	"Is this server allowed to send mail for this domain?"
DKIM	"Was this message actually signed by the domain, and unaltered in transit?"
DMARC	"If SPF or DKIM fails, what should I do with the message — and who do I tell?"

SPF — Sender Policy Framework

SPF is a public list of servers permitted to send mail using your domain. If mail arrives from a server not on the list, the receiver knows it's unauthorized.

It's a single TXT record on the root of your domain.

```
Type:  TXT
Host:  @           (some registrars want the bare domain, e.g. getcoreflare.com)
Value: v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all
TTL:   3600
```

If you also send through Mailgun from the same domain, include it in the *same* record:

```
v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com include:mailgun.org ~all
```

The mistakes that break SPF:

- **Two SPF records on one domain.** This is an instant permanent-error. Merge them into one record with multiple `include:` statements. Never publish a second `v=spf1` line.
- **More than 10 DNS lookups.** Every `include:` costs lookups, and nested includes count too. Exceed 10 and SPF fails outright. Keep the record lean — remove includes for services you no longer use.

- **Using +a11.** That authorizes the entire internet to send as you. Use ~a11 (softfail) while you're setting up, and -a11 (hardfail) once you're certain every legitimate sender is listed.

DKIM — DomainKeys Identified Mail

DKIM adds a cryptographic signature to every outgoing message. The receiving server fetches your public key from DNS and verifies the signature. Pass means the mail genuinely came from your domain and wasn't tampered with en route.

In Google Workspace:

1. Admin console → **Apps** → **Google Workspace** → **Gmail** → **Authenticate email**.
2. Select the domain, choose a **2048-bit** key, and click **Generate new record**.
3. Google gives you a host (usually google._domainkey) and a long TXT value starting v=DKIM1;.
4. Add it at your DNS provider.
5. Wait for propagation — often minutes, sometimes up to 48 hours — then return to the same screen and click **Start authentication**.

```
Type:  TXT
Host:  google._domainkey
Value: v=DKIM1; k=rsa; p=MIIBIjANBgkqhkiG9w0BAQEFAAOCAQ8AMIIBCgKCAQEA...
      (paste the full key exactly as generated – no line breaks, no spaces)
TTL:   3600
```

Mailgun issues its own DKIM record under a different selector — commonly mailo._domainkey.yourdomain.com or a selector shown in the Mailgun dashboard. Multiple DKIM records are fine, unlike SPF. Each lives under its own selector and they don't conflict.

The step people skip: generating the key is not enabling DKIM. In Google Workspace you must come back and click **Start authentication** after DNS propagates. Until you do, you're publishing a key nobody is signing with.

DMARC — the policy layer

DMARC ties SPF and DKIM together. It tells receivers what to do when a message fails both, and it sends you reports on who is sending mail as your domain.

Start permissive. Tighten later.

```
Type:  TXT
Host:  _dmarc
```

```
Value: v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@getcoreflare.com; fo=1; pct=100
TTL: 3600
```

Reading the tags:

- `p=none` — monitor only. Nothing gets blocked. Start here.
- `p=quarantine` — failing mail goes to spam. Move here after 2 to 4 weeks of clean reports.
- `p=reject` — failing mail is refused outright. Strongest protection, but only once you're certain every legitimate sender passes.
- `rua=` — where aggregate reports get sent. Use a real inbox you'll actually read.
- `fo=1` — generate a report if either SPF or DKIM fails, not just when both do.
- `pct=100` — apply the policy to all mail.

Do not jump straight to `p=reject`. If some legitimate sender — your CRM, your invoicing tool, a form notifier — isn't authenticated, you'll silently kill your own mail.

Verify all three actually pass

Publishing records is not the same as passing checks. Verify every domain, every time.

Method 1 — the manual inbox test (most reliable). Send a real email from each new inbox to a personal Gmail address. Open it, click the three-dot menu, choose **Show original**. You want to see:

```
SPF: PASS with IP 209.85.xxx.xxx
DKIM: PASS with domain getcoreflare.com
DMARC: PASS with policy p=NONE
```

Three PASS lines. Anything less and you fix it before sending another email.

Method 2 — free authentication checkers. MXToolbox and Google Admin Toolbox CheckMX let you query each record type by domain. Useful for catching a duplicate SPF record or a truncated DKIM key.

Method 3 — a seed test. Send a plain test message to accounts you control across Gmail, Outlook, and Yahoo. Check whether it lands in Primary, Promotions, or Spam. That tells you placement, not just authentication — and placement is what actually matters.

Method 4 — Instantly's built-in checker. Once inboxes are connected, Instantly flags authentication problems per account. Fix every flag before launching. A single misconfigured inbox drags the whole pool's reputation.

Do all four for the first domain. Do at least methods 1 and 4 for every domain after.

Phase 3 — Warmup

Why it matters

A brand-new domain has no reputation. Not good, not bad — none. To a mailbox provider, an unknown domain that suddenly sends 300 emails in a day looks exactly like a spam operation, because that is exactly what a spam operation looks like.

Warmup builds a history. It generates the signals filters look for: mail being opened, replied to, marked "not spam," moved out of Promotions. Over weeks, that history says "this domain sends mail people want."

Skip warmup and you burn a domain in days. You'll pay for new domains and start over — having lost more time than warmup would have taken.

How to run it

Enable warmup in Instantly on every inbox the moment it's connected and authenticated. The tool exchanges mail with a pool of other real inboxes, opens it, replies to it, and rescues it from spam folders automatically.

Settings that work:

- **Start:** 2 to 4 warmup emails per day per inbox.
- **Ramp:** increase by roughly 2 to 4 per day.
- **Ceiling:** 30 to 40 warmup emails per day per inbox.
- **Reply rate:** 30 to 40 percent. High enough to signal engagement, not so high it looks synthetic.
- **Never turn it off.** Warmup runs permanently underneath live campaigns, at a reduced level. It's a floor under your reputation.

A realistic 6-week ramp

Week	Warmup/day/inbox	Cold sends/day/inbox	What you're doing
1	2 → 10	0	Warmup only. Verify authentication passes. Build the list.
2	10 → 20	0	Warmup only. Scrub and verify the list. Write the sequence.

3	20 → 30	5–10	First live sends, tightest segment only. Watch bounces daily.
4	30	15–20	Scale only if bounce rate is under 3% and no spam placement.
5	30	25–30	Widen the segment. Start A/B testing subject lines.
6+	20–30 (maintenance)	30–50	Steady state. Warmup stays on permanently.

Four weeks is the compressed version and it carries risk. Six weeks is what I'd actually recommend. The extra fortnight costs you almost nothing and protects an asset you'll use for years.

What to watch during warmup

- **Warmup deliverability score in Instantly.** You want it climbing toward and holding above 90%. Flat or falling means something is wrong — usually authentication.
- **Spam placement rate.** Should trend to near zero by week 3. If warmup mail is still landing in spam at week 3, stop. Do not launch. Recheck SPF, DKIM, DMARC, and the domain's blacklist status.
- **Inbox-provider spread.** If Google inboxes look fine but Outlook placement is poor, that's a Microsoft-specific reputation issue. Slow the ramp and give it more time.

Phase 4 — List Building

Define the ICP before you touch a database

A vague list produces vague results and burns domains on people who were never going to buy. Write your ideal customer profile down before sourcing a single contact.

Five things, minimum:

1. **Industry or vertical** — "marketing agencies," not "businesses."
2. **Company size** — headcount band. 5–20 people behaves nothing like 200–500.
3. **Role / title** — the person with budget authority AND the pain. Sometimes that's two different people.
4. **Geography and timezone** — determines your sending window.
5. **A trigger** — something observable that says *now* is the moment. Hiring for a role you'd replace. Recently funded. Running ads. Just launched something.

Example ICP: *US-based marketing agencies, 5–25 employees, targeting the founder or head of ops, currently hiring a coordinator or VA.* That last clause is the trigger — it tells you they're feeling the operational load right now.

A tight ICP means better replies from fewer sends, which means less volume, which means less infrastructure and less reputation risk. Everything downstream gets easier.

Sourcing

- **B2B databases** — Apollo, Clay, and similar. Fast and filterable. Data quality varies, so verification is mandatory.
- **LinkedIn Sales Navigator** — best filtering available. Build the list there, then enrich for emails.
- **Job boards** — an active posting is a live buying trigger, plus a free description of their pain.
- **Manual research** — slowest, highest quality. For high-ticket offers, a hand-built 200-contact list beats a scraped 5,000.

Whatever the source, capture the fields your personalization needs — first name, company, role, and at least one specific detail you can reference in email one. If you can't personalize it, it doesn't belong in the list.

Verification — the step that saves your domain

Bounce rate is the fastest way to kill a domain. Faster than bad copy. Faster than spam complaints.

Here's the mechanism. Every bounce is a message to a mailbox that doesn't exist. Legitimate senders maintain their lists, so their bounce rates are low. Spammers blast unverified data, so theirs are high. Mailbox providers use that ratio as a primary trust signal. A spike in bounces reads as "this sender didn't earn this list" — and filtering tightens across everything you send.

A single campaign to an unverified list can undo six weeks of warmup in an afternoon.

Thresholds to hold yourself to:

Bounce rate	Status	Action
Under 2%	Healthy	Continue.
2–3%	Acceptable ceiling	Continue, but re-verify the next batch.

3–5%	Warning	Pause. Re-verify the remaining list before sending again.
Over 5%	Danger	Stop the campaign. Re-verify everything. Give the domain a few days of warmup-only before resuming.

Aim to keep bounce rate under 3%. Under 2% if you can.

The scrubbing process:

1. Run the full list through a verification service — NeverBounce, ZeroBounce, MillionVerifier, Bouncer. Cost is fractions of a cent per contact. Cheaper than a burned domain by orders of magnitude.
2. **Delete every "invalid."** No exceptions.
3. **Delete every "catch-all" / "accept-all"** unless the account is genuinely high value. Catch-alls accept everything at the server and bounce silently later — you find out after the damage.
4. **Delete every role address** — info@, admin@, support@, sales@, contact@. High complaint risk, low reply rate.
5. **Dedupe by email and by company domain.** Three people at one company getting near-identical mail in the same week is a complaint waiting to happen.
6. **Re-verify anything older than 90 days.** B2B email data decays continuously as people change jobs.

Do this before every campaign. Not once. Every time.

Phase 5 — Sequence Structure

Five emails over roughly 14 days. Each one has a job. None of them are longer than they need to be.

Principles before the copy:

- **Under 100 words.** Most cold email gets read on a phone. If it needs scrolling, it gets archived.
- **One ask per email.** Two asks means no decision.
- **Specific beats clever.** "I noticed you're hiring a coordinator" outperforms any wordplay.
- **No attachments. No images. Links only from email three onward, and one at most.**
- **Send follow-ups on the same thread** so context travels with the message.
- **Any reply stops the sequence.** Configure this in Instantly. Nothing burns goodwill like an automated follow-up after someone already answered.

Merge fields below: {{first_name}}, {{company}}, {{custom_detail}}.

Email 1 — Day 0 — The relevance opener

Job: prove in one line that this isn't a blast. Ask a question that's easy to answer, not a meeting.

Subject: quick question about {{company}}

Hi {{first_name}},

Saw {{company}} is hiring a client coordinator — usually that means the admin load is outgrowing the team.

I build automated systems that handle the repetitive side of that: lead follow-up, booking, CRM updates. It runs in the background so the team handles the work that actually needs a human.

Worth a quick look, or is this handled already?

Samme

Why it works: the subject is lowercase and low-stakes — it reads like a colleague, not a campaign. Line one is observable and specific to them. The offer is one sentence with a concrete outcome. And the close gives them a genuine out, which paradoxically makes replies more likely — "is this handled already?" is easier to answer than "do you want to book a call?"

Email 2 — Day 3 — The specific proof

Job: show them what it actually looks like. Concrete mechanics, no vague promises.

Subject: (reply on the same thread — no new subject)

{{first_name}} — to be concrete about what I mean:

A new lead comes in. Within 60 seconds they get a personalised reply, a booking link, and a reminder sequence if they don't book. If they do book, the CRM updates itself and the team gets a Slack ping with the context already attached.

No one touches it manually. It just runs.

Want me to map what that would look like for {{company}}?

Samme

Why it works: email one made a claim, email two shows the mechanism. People buy what they can picture. Note there's no metric here — no "saves 20 hours a week." Unverifiable numbers cost you

credibility with the exact skeptical buyer you want. The ask escalates gently: a map, not a meeting.

Email 3 — Day 6 — The value drop

Job: give something away with no strings. This is the first and only link.

Subject: (same thread)

{{first_name}}, regardless of whether we ever talk —

I put together a breakdown of the follow-up sequence most agencies are missing between "lead enquires" and "lead books." It's the gap where most of them leak revenue.

Here it is: [link]

No form, no signup. Take it and use it.

Samme

Why it works: reciprocity, done honestly. "Regardless of whether we ever talk" removes the transaction, which is what makes it land. "No form, no signup" pre-empts the reflex that every link is a gate. It also filters — anyone who clicks has told you they're in market, and you can prioritise them.

Email 4 — Day 10 — The direct ask

Job: make the actual request, plainly. No more warming up.

Subject: (same thread)

{{first_name}} — direct version.

15 minutes. I'll walk through the two or three automations I'd build first for {{company}}, and roughly what each one takes off your plate.

If it's useful we talk further. If not, you keep the plan.

Does Thursday or Friday work better?

Samme

Why it works: "direct version" acknowledges the sequence without apologising for it — buyers respect that. The time cost is stated up front. "You keep the plan" makes the downside zero. And the close is an either/or, which is easier to answer than an open-ended one.

Email 5 — Day 14 — The clean close

Job: end the thread with dignity and leave the door open.

```
Subject: (same thread)

{{first_name}} — closing the loop on this one.

I'll assume the timing isn't right and stop here. No hard feelings.

If it changes — Q3 planning, new hire, whatever — reply to this thread
and I'll pick it straight back up.

All the best,
Samme
```

Why it works: a genuine close, not fake scarcity. No "last chance," no "should I close your file?" Those read as manipulation and people can smell it. This one often gets the highest reply rate in the sequence, because the pressure is genuinely gone. Naming plausible future triggers gives them a hook to come back on.

Sequence settings

- **Stop on reply.** Always.
- **Spacing:** 3, 3, 4, 4 days. Skip weekends.
- **Two subject-line variants on email one only.** Changing more than one thing at a time tells you nothing.
- **Sample size:** 200+ sends per variant before you call a winner.
- **Push replies into GoHighLevel** as opportunities so nothing sits in an inbox unmanaged.

Phase 6 — Deliverability Maintenance

Deliverability isn't a setup task. It's a weekly habit.

Spam-trigger language

Modern filters weigh patterns, not single words. But some language reliably correlates with bulk mail and stacking it raises your risk for no upside.

Avoid in subject lines and first paragraphs: free, guarantee, guaranteed, act now, limited time, risk-free, no obligation, click here, buy now, order now, cash, income, earn \$, make money, 100%,

urgent, congratulations, winner, exclusive deal, best price, special promotion, this won't last.

Also avoid the formatting tells:

- ALL CAPS in the subject line
- Multiple exclamation marks
- Excessive bold, colour, or large fonts
- Currency symbols and percentages in the subject
- Emoji in cold outreach subject lines

Best test: read your subject line out loud. If it sounds like an ad, rewrite it. If it sounds like something a colleague would type in ten seconds, send it.

Plain text wins

Send plain text. Not "HTML styled to look plain" — actually plain.

Why: HTML email carries tracking pixels, styling, and structure that mark it as bulk. Plain text looks like a person typing. That's the whole strategy of cold email — a one-to-one message that happens to be automated.

- **No HTML templates, no header images, no branded footers.**
- **Signature: name and role. Two lines.** No logo, no banner, no social icons, no legal block.
- **Consider turning open tracking off.** Tracking pixels are a spam signal, and open rates have been unreliable since Apple Mail Privacy Protection started pre-loading images. You lose a vanity metric and gain deliverability. Replies are the metric that matters.

Links and images

- **Zero links in emails one and two.** Not even in the signature. First contact with a link is a bulk-mail pattern.
- **One link maximum** from email three onward.
- **Never use link shorteners.** Bit.ly and similar are heavily abused and heavily filtered.
- **Link to a domain with reputation** — your main site, your Calendly. Not a fresh, unindexed page.
- **No images. No attachments. Ever.** Attachments in cold email are close to an automatic spam flag.

Sending windows

- **Tuesday through Thursday** perform best. Monday is buried, Friday is checked out.

- **8:00 AM to 4:00 PM in the recipient's timezone.** Set this per campaign in Instantly, matched to your list's geography.
- **Never send on weekends.** Weekend cold email reads as automated because it is.
- **Randomise the delay between sends** — 60 to 180 seconds. Perfectly regular intervals are a machine signature.
- **Spread across the whole window.** Don't dump the day's volume in one hour.

Weekly metrics review

Fifteen minutes, same time every week. Check these five:

Metric	Healthy range	If it's off
Bounce rate	Under 3%	Pause and re-verify the list immediately. Highest priority signal.
Spam complaint rate	Under 0.1%	Targeting or copy is wrong. Tighten the ICP before touching the copy.
Warmup deliverability score	Above 90%	Recheck authentication and blacklist status. Slow sends.
Reply rate	Trending, not absolute	Compare week over week and campaign to campaign. A sudden drop usually means placement, not copy.
Unsubscribe rate	Low and stable	A spike means you're hitting the wrong people. Better than complaints — but fix the list.

Other weekly habits:

- **Blacklist check** each sending domain on MXToolbox. Monthly minimum, weekly while scaling.
- **Rotate rested inboxes in** rather than pushing existing ones past 50/day.
- **Read the actual replies**, not just the dashboard. The objections people write are the fastest copy feedback you'll ever get.

One thing worth naming plainly: keep an unsubscribe path available and honour it within 24 hours. A plain line — "Reply 'stop' and I won't contact you again" — is enough, and it's a legal requirement in most jurisdictions you'll be sending into. Suppress those contacts permanently across every campaign and every domain.

Phase 7 — Reply Handling

Replies are where campaigns are won or lost. Speed matters more than polish. **Respond within 2 hours during business hours.** The gap between a 20-minute reply and a next-day reply is

enormous, because you're competing with everything else in their inbox.

Five categories

Category	What it looks like	Action
Interested	"Tell me more," "send times," "how much?"	Reply within the hour. Send the booking link. Move to opportunity in GoHighLevel.
Not now	"Circle back in Q3," "revisiting next quarter"	Agree, confirm the date, set a task. This is a yes with a timestamp.
Objection	"We already have someone," "too expensive," "not a priority"	Answer once, briefly. One follow-up maximum. See below.
Referral	"That's not me — talk to Sarah"	Thank them, ask for the intro, then open a new thread with the reference.
Hard no	"Remove me," "stop," "not interested"	Suppress permanently across all campaigns and domains. Do not reply beyond a one-line acknowledgement.

Handling the four common objections

"We already work with someone." Don't attack the incumbent. Position beside them.

Makes sense — most teams I speak to already have someone on the marketing side. What I do usually sits underneath that: the automation and follow-up layer between a lead arriving and a call happening.

Happy to send a one-page map of what that layer would look like for you. No call needed. Want it?

"How much does it cost?" Price without scope is a trap. Reframe, don't dodge.

Depends entirely on scope — a single automated follow-up sequence and a full CRM build are very different projects.

Quickest path: 15 minutes to scope what you actually need, then I give you a fixed number, not a range. Does Thursday work?

"Not a priority right now." Accept it. Book the future.

Understood. When does it become one — is that a Q3 thing, or more tied to headcount?

Happy to check back at the right moment rather than the wrong one.

"Send me some information." Often a polite brush-off. Send something real, and keep a hook.

Sending now – it's a short breakdown of the three automations I'd build first for a team your size.

One question so I point you at the right part: is the bottleneck lead follow-up, or what happens after the call is booked?

That closing question is doing the work. It converts a dead-end into a conversation.

The handoff to a booked call

Once someone shows interest, get to the calendar in as few messages as possible. Every extra round trip loses people.

- 1. **Reply fast, and short.** Two or three sentences.
- 2. **Send one Calendly link.** Not "let me know what works" — that pushes the work onto them.
- 3. **Offer a specific alternative** for people who don't like booking links: "or tell me a time Thursday and I'll send an invite."
- 4. **Set the agenda in one line.** "15 minutes, I'll walk through what I'd build first." People show up to defined meetings and skip vague ones.
- 5. **Confirm the same day** with a short note including the agenda.
- 6. **Automate reminders** — 24 hours and 1 hour before — through GoHighLevel. This is the single highest-leverage automation in the whole funnel, because no-shows are pure waste.
- 7. **Move the record out of the email tool.** Once a call is booked, the contact lives in GoHighLevel as an opportunity, not in an inbox. Inboxes are not a CRM.

Phase 8 — Troubleshooting

Symptom, likely cause, fix. Work top to bottom within each symptom — the causes are ordered by how often they're the real culprit.

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Landing in spam	SPF, DKIM, or DMARC failing	Send a test to a personal Gmail, open "Show original," confirm three PASS lines. Fix any that don't pass before sending anything else.

	Warmup skipped or cut short	Pause the campaign. Run warmup-only for 2 to 3 weeks. Restart at 5 to 10 sends per inbox per day.
	Domain or IP blacklisted	Check on MXToolbox. Follow each listing's delisting process. Address the underlying cause first, or you'll be relisted.
	Spam-trigger language or heavy HTML	Strip to plain text. Remove images, attachments, and the branded signature. Rewrite the subject to something a colleague would type.
	Volume scaled too fast	Cut daily sends by half. Hold for a week. Ramp back at 5 to 10 per inbox per week.
Low open rate	Landing in spam (opens can't happen from the spam folder)	Run a seed test across Gmail, Outlook, and Yahoo to confirm placement. Treat as the spam symptom above if confirmed.
	Weak subject line	Rewrite to lowercase, under 6 words, specific to them. A/B test two variants on email one only, 200+ sends each.
	Sender name looks generic	Use a real first and last name, not a company name. Add a profile photo to the inbox.
	Open tracking is under-reporting	Apple Mail Privacy Protection distorts open data. Consider turning tracking off entirely and judging on replies instead.
Opens but no replies	Wrong ICP — the message doesn't apply to them	Tighten the profile. Add a trigger (hiring, funding, running ads). Better targeting fixes this faster than better copy.
	Offer is vague or feature-led	Rewrite around one concrete outcome. Describe the mechanism, not the benefit adjective.
	The ask is too big for a first touch	Swap "book a call" for a low-friction question in emails one and two. Escalate to the meeting ask at email four.
	Emails are too long	Cut to under 100 words. If it needs scrolling on a phone, it's too long.
High bounce rate	List was never verified	Stop sending immediately. Run the whole list through NeverBounce or ZeroBounce. Delete every invalid.
	Catch-all domains included	Remove all catch-all / accept-all addresses. They bounce silently after acceptance.
	Stale data	Re-verify anything sourced more than 90 days ago. B2B data decays constantly.
	Role addresses in the list	Strip info@, admin@, support@, sales@, contact@. High bounce and high complaint risk.

Domain blacklisted	Bounce spike from an unverified list	Stop all sending on that domain. Verify everything. Request delisting through the listing provider. Run warmup-only for 2 to 4 weeks before resuming.
	Spam complaints above threshold	Review who you targeted and what you said. Narrow the ICP hard. Make the opt-out line obvious and honour it within 24 hours.
	Domain had a bad history before you bought it	Check archive.org and blacklist history. If it was poisoned pre-purchase, retire it — recovery costs more than a new domain.
	Shared IP contaminated by another sender	Ask your provider about dedicated IP options, or move sending to a cleaner provider. On Mailgun, check whether you're on a shared pool.

The rule when something breaks

Stop sending first. Diagnose second.

Every email you send while a problem is active makes the reputation damage deeper and the recovery longer. Pausing for 48 hours costs you two days. Sending through a deliverability problem costs you a domain.

The Short Version

1. **Never send from your main domain.** Buy secondaries and treat them as consumable.
2. **2 to 3 inboxes per domain. 30 to 50 cold sends per inbox per day. That's the ceiling.**
3. **SPF, DKIM, DMARC — verified with three PASS lines in a real inbox test.** Not "configured." Verified.
4. **Warm up for 4 to 6 weeks before the first campaign, and never turn warmup off.**
5. **Verify every list, every time. Keep bounce rate under 3%.**
6. **Plain text. No images. No attachments. One link at most, from email three onward.**
7. **Five emails over 14 days. Under 100 words each. Stop on reply.**
8. **Reply within 2 hours. One link to the calendar. Automate the reminders.**
9. **Check five metrics weekly. When something breaks, stop sending before you diagnose.**

None of this is complicated. It's just sequential, and almost everyone skips steps two and three because they're boring. Those are the two that decide whether any of the rest matters.

Do the boring parts properly. The results follow.

Want This Built For You?

I build cold email infrastructure end to end — domains, inboxes, authentication, warmup, list, sequences, and the CRM handoff in GoHighLevel — so the system runs without you babysitting it.

If you'd rather have it built and handed over working than assemble it yourself, get in touch.

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Figures in this guide are operational guidelines drawn from standard cold email practice, not measured results from any specific campaign. Deliverability outcomes vary by industry, list quality, and offer.